markets.

This trade gradually increased in the third and second centuries **B.C.** and then these adventurous traders and merchants may have been followed by missionaries, for this was just the period after Ashoka. The old stories in Sanskrit contain many accounts of perilous sea voyages and of shipwrecks. Both Greek and Arab

East' (Calcutta, 1927), and his 'Svarnadvipa' (Calcutta, 1937). Also to the publications

of the Greater India Society (Calcutta).

accounts show that there was regular maritime intercourse between India and the Far East at least as early as the first century **A.C.** The Malay Peninsula and the Indonesian Islands lay on the direct trade route between China and India, Persia, Arabia, and the Mediterranean. Apart from their geographical importance these countries contained valuable minerals, metals, spices, and timber. Malaya was then, as now, famous for its tin mines. Probably the earliest voyages were along the east coast of India-Kalinga (Orissa), Bengal, Burma and then down the Malay Peninsula. Later the direct sea routes from east and south India were developed. It was along this sea route that many Chinese pilgrims came to India.